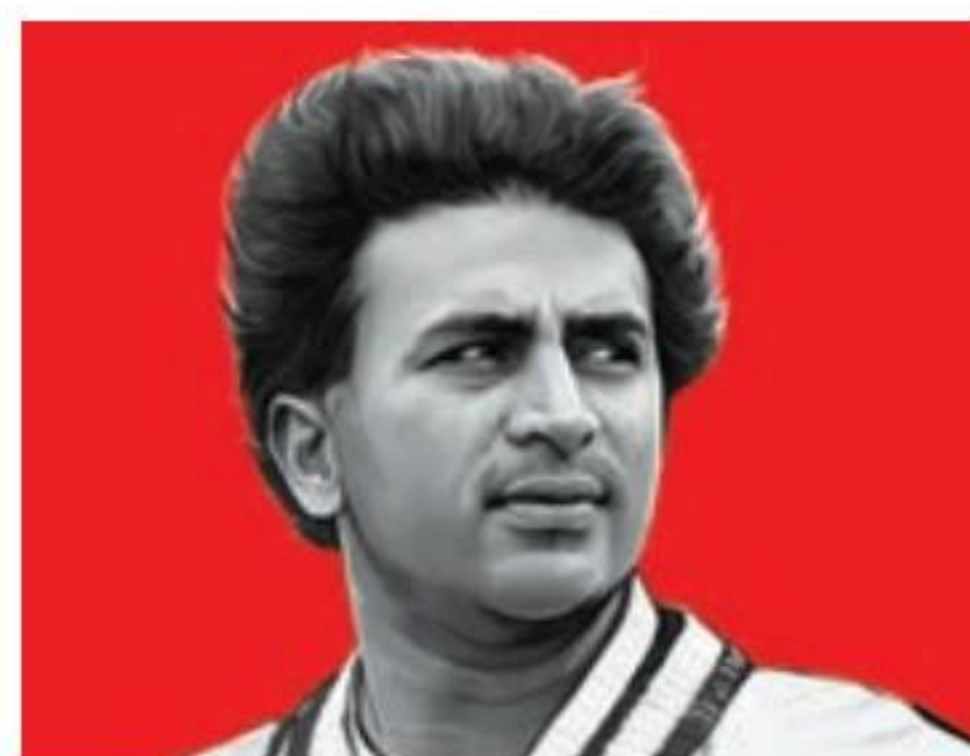




ON THE WRITE LINE

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BATTERS WILL HAVE TO FIND A NEW WAY TO BREACH THE RED LIGHTS ONCE AGAIN

SRH's aggressive batting is **faltering** as bowlers adapt. Slower balls and bouncers expose their top order. To succeed, they must rethink their approach.

There is something about speed, isn't there? Speed thrills but also sometimes kills. Last year, the Sunrisers Hyderabad, with their openers Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma, set up a new template for how to bat in the Powerplay as well as beyond. They batted at breakneck speed, taking the opposition completely by surprise, and as a result, their team came very close to crossing the 300-run mark in the IPL. Their batting was like youngsters in their fancy sports cars going through traffic red lights and not being caught.

This year, in the first match, SRH went through the red light without being caught. But just as the traffic police get smarter and capture those offending cars, so too have the bowlers of IPL teams started to put the brakes on not just SRH but also other teams trying to emulate them. SRH have now, at the time of writing, lost four consecutive matches, where the top three have not made much of a contribution. Bowling slower deliveries and mixing them with the odd one into the ribcage of the batters has resulted in them holing out to the fielder at deep square-leg and being dismissed in the Powerplay itself. The batters will certainly have to find a new way to try and breach the red lights once again.

That said, the 200 mark is being reached quite regularly — thanks mainly to batters going into fifth gear in the last quarter of the innings. As the summer gets hotter and pitches get drier,

the spinners will come more into play, and we may not see 200-plus scores as frequently as we have in the first couple of weeks. The first couple of weeks have also shown that there is a big difference between smashing sixes and fours in the State premier league, where the attack is short of national or international class and the boundaries even shorter. In the IPL, with stronger attacks, sharper bowlers, and the use of technology to discern the strengths and weaknesses of the batters, most of the big hitters from the State premier leagues have hardly troubled the scorers. Likewise, some of the fast bowlers who were bought for crores are proving even more expensive on the field.

In the IPL auction, there is generally a trend to look at one or two international fast bowlers and believe that Indian bowlers who come off a slightly long run-up will be able to do the same. However, these are uncapped players, short on experience, and thus found wanting under the intense pressure of the IPL. Apart from fast bowlers, leg-spinners — both right and left-handed — are the flavour of the IPL, though again, most of them end up not being worth the sums spent on them.

The spate of injuries to India's budding fast bowlers is a real cause for concern. When you look at the names of those at the NCA in Bengaluru, you get a sense of the hazards of trying to bowl fast. There is a certain commonality to the injuries, which begs the question of whether the gym training they do is